The WTO also sought to strengthen partnerships with other trade organizations, such as the OECD and UNCTAD,[71] and embraced initiatives like plurilateral agreements that allowed subsets of members to negotiate rules on specific issues (Hoekman and Sabel 2021). These measures demonstrated the organization's adaptability and its commitment to advancing its mission despite external resistance.

Simultaneously, the WTO attempted to appease the Trump administration by addressing some of its grievances. It pursued discussions on reforming the dispute-settlement mechanism and improving transparency. Efforts by Japan and the EU included exploring ways to limit the binding nature of certain rulings and addressing US concerns about Chinese trade practices, such as state-owned enterprises and forced technology transfers (Hopewell 2021). The WTO also engaged the United States behind closed doors[72] as former director general Roberto Azevêdo maintained frequent contact with US trade representatives to seek common ground.[73] However, these efforts yielded limited success, as the administration repeatedly rejected proposed reforms without offering concrete alternatives.

Recognizing the importance of public perception, the WTO also reached out to American citizens, emphasizing the benefits of multilateralism and free trade.[74] Through social media campaigns and public statements, it highlighted how global trade rules promote economic stability and prosperity, aiming to counter the narrative that the WTO exclusively served elites or multinational corporations.[75]

Although the WTO survived Trump's first presidency, the damage dealt to its operations was significant. The Appellate Body remains incapacitated, and progress on multilateral trade negotiations has stalled. Yet the organization has demonstrated resilience. The MPIA has introduced innovative reforms (Pelc 2024), and the panel system continues to adjudicate disputes effectively, often adhering to the precedents set by the now-defunct Appellate Body (Howse and Langille 2023). Moreover, the WTO has retained its global membership, and its core functions remain intact.

The shadow of Trump's policies lingers, as his populist rhetoric continues to resonate with key segments of the US electorate.[76] His influence extended to the subsequent administration, with Biden largely